

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

LATER WITTGENSTEIN - Layered Solved-Practice Workbook - Philosophy Paper I Western Philosophy 08

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

PHILOSOPHY PAPER I | WESTERN PHILOSOPHY 08

LATER WITTGENSTEIN

From picturing facts to meaning as use: language-games, forms of life, and the dissolution of philosophical problems.

THE TURN - one thinker, two pictures of meaning



THREE PILLARS OF THE LATER PHILOSOPHY



meaning lives in public, criterion-governed practice - not in a private inner object



"Don't think, but look": describe use, assemble a perspicuous view

- and philosophy "leaves everything as it is" (PI 124).

Meaning as use, grounded in forms of life; the private-language argument dissolves the Cartesian inner; philosophy becomes therapy, not theory.

Owens exactly 7 Western Philosophy PYQ parts, 2018-2025 - one each year except 2021.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

LATER WITTGENSTEIN - Layered Solved-Practice Workbook

- Philosophy Paper I Western Philosophy 08

Workbook Source Audit

- Exact PYQ wording, year and marks: local Western Philosophy Paper I bank, 2018-2025.
- Exactly 7 owner questions, one each in 2018, 2019, 2020, 2022, 2023, 2024 and 2025; 2021 is the only year without one.
- Early-Wittgenstein (Tractatus) and Logical-Positivism parts are owned by their own clauses and are used here only as labelled comparisons, never counted among the 7.
- Printed anomalies preserved verbatim: 2022 Q1(c) prints "motion" for "notion"; 2025 Q3(a) retains an unmatched opening quotation before "logical structure".
- Model solutions authored at examiner grade: thesis -> named PI section / quotation -> analysis -> objection/reply -> verdict.
- MCQs: 32 core plus 8 remedial, exactly 40, strict A-B-C-D rotation ten times.
- Original Mains: one solved 10-marker, one solved 15-marker and one solved 20-marker.
- Contemporary linkage is not forced: no verified 2026 news anchor exists, so none is invented; the standing relevance is the clause's permanent place in the philosophy of language and mind.
- Final consolidated register notes are intentionally excluded from this workbook.

Practice Design

The workbook sequence is the seven exact verified PYQs -> 32 core MCQs -> 8 remedial MCQs -> original 10/15/20-mark Mains practice. There are no register notes and no canonical apparatus block in this workbook.

DIRECTIVE -> THESIS -> DOCTRINE -> NAMED PI SECTION / EXAMPLE -> OBJECTION/REPLY -> VERDICT

SOLVED PYQ BANK - EXACTLY 7 VERIFIED OWNER QUESTIONS

Exact wording, year and marks are parsed from the continuous local Western Philosophy Paper I bank for 2018-2025. Later Wittgenstein owns exactly 7 primary parts, one each in 2018, 2019, 2020, 2022, 2023, 2024 and 2025; 2021 is the only year without one. Early-Wittgenstein and Logical-Positivism questions are used only as labelled comparisons and are never counted here. Two printed anomalies are preserved verbatim and explained: the 2022 paper prints "motion" for "notion", and the 2025 paper retains an unmatched opening quotation before "logical structure".

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q1(c), 10 marks

Question: How does the notion of 'family resemblance' help Wittgenstein to uphold that 'Language is a game'? Discuss.

Model solution

Directive: "Discuss" at 10 marks - explain the *mechanism* by which family resemblance supports the thesis, not merely define terms. Answer in about 150 words.

Thesis. Family resemblance is the device that lets Wittgenstein say "language is a game" *without* smuggling in a hidden essence of language.

Body.

- *Family resemblance defined.* Asked what all games share, we find "a complicated network of similarities overlapping and criss-crossing" - board, card, ball, Olympic and solitary games - but **no single feature common to all**. Cases are related like a family (nose, gait, temperament), not by an essence. Method: "Don't think, but look!"

- *The transfer to "language"*. "Language" is exactly such a concept: reporting, joking, ordering, praying and thanking share no common essence, only overlapping resemblances - the countless language-games. - *Why this upholds "language is a game"*. Because "game" itself has no essence, calling language "a game" does **not** assert a concealed common nature; it *dissolves* the demand for one and redirects us to describe uses.

Verdict. Family resemblance converts an apparent metaphor into a precise anti-essentialist claim: meaning is use across a family of games, not conformity to one hidden form.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2019 Q3(b), 15 marks

Question: Show how Wittgenstein's critique of solipsism culminates in the critique of private language.

Model solution

Directive: "Show how... culminates in..." at 15 marks - trace a *movement* from solipsism to the private-language conclusion. Answer in about 250 words.

Thesis. Wittgenstein's critique of solipsism does not refute it with a rival metaphysics; it *dissolves* it by showing that the solipsist's supposed private inner world could not even be *put into language* - and that demonstration **is** the private-language argument.

Body.

- *The solipsist premise.* The solipsist claims that what is really known is only his own present inner experience; the "external" world and other minds are doubtful constructions. To assert even this, he must be able to *speak* of his private inner contents. - *The demand for a criterion of correctness.* From the rule-following considerations (PI 201), using any word correctly requires a standard independent of one's mere impression of being right; meaning needs the possibility of a mistake. - *The diary (PI 258).* When the solipsist tries to name a purely private sensation "S", he has no independent check that a later "S" is the *same*; "whatever is going to seem right to me is right. And that only means that here we can't talk about 'right'." The private naming fails to establish even one rule. - *The beetle (PI 293).* If "beetle" names only what is in one's own private box, the object "drops out as irrelevant" - "the box might even be empty." Public use, not the private object, carries meaning.

Culmination. Thus the private inner world the solipsist privileges cannot be *said* at all; the language he needs is impossible. **The critique of solipsism therefore culminates in the critique of private language** - not by denying inner life, but by denying it the role of a private semantic foundation.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2020 Q4(c), 15 marks

Question: "But could we also imagine a language in which a person could write down or give vocal expression to his inner experiences—his feelings, moods and the rest—for his private use?" Critically discuss the answer offered by Wittgenstein to this question.

Model solution

Directive: "Critically discuss the answer offered by Wittgenstein" at 15 marks - state his answer, then assess it (raise and rebut the behaviourism charge). Answer in about 250 words. The quoted question is PI 243-style: could a person give vocal or written expression to inner experiences "for his private use"?

Thesis. Wittgenstein's answer is **No** - a *logically* private language is impossible - and the argument leaves inner life intact while denying it the role of a private meaning-foundation.

Body.

- *Fix the target.* "Private" means **logically** private: signs for sensations only the speaker could in principle know - not a secret code (translatable) and not soliloquy (public language spoken quietly).
- *No criterion of correctness (PI 258).* Naming a private sensation "S" provides no independent standard of "same again"; "whatever seems right... we can't talk about 'right'." Without a possible mistake there is no meaning. - *The beetle (PI 293).* The private object "drops out as irrelevant"; meaning is fixed by public use. - *Public, defeasible criteria (PI 580).* Sensation-words are anchored to "outward criteria" - grammatical, not merely inductive, and **defeasible**.

Critical assessment.

- *Objection - behaviourism*. Does this reduce pain to pain-behaviour? - *Reply*. No: criteria are **defeasible** (one can wince without pain - pretence), so pain and behaviour can come apart; PI 304 - "not a something, but not a nothing either"; PI 307-308 reject the inner *object* as semantic foundation ("grammatical fiction"), not the inner life. First-person "It hurts" is an **avowal**, not a criterion-based report.

Verdict. The answer is compelling as a *dissolution* of the Cartesian private foundation; it occupies a third position between inner-object semantics and behaviourism, though critics complain "criterion" is left under-specified.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2022 Q1(c), 10 marks

Question: Establish the tenability of later Wittgenstein's motion of language as form of life.

Printed-wording anomaly (preserved verbatim): Printed wording: the official English line itself prints "**motion**"; it is retained rather than silently changed to "notion".

Model solution

Directive: "Establish the tenability" at 10 marks - argue *for* the defensibility of the doctrine, with a measured limit. Answer in about 150 words.

Printed-wording anomaly (preserved verbatim): the official English paper prints "later Wittgenstein's **motion** of language as form of life." "Motion" is a printed slip for "**notion**"; the intended thesis is "the *notion* of language as a form of life." Reproduce the printed word once, note the slip, then answer the intended question - this is the provenance discipline UPSC rewards.

Thesis. The notion of language as a form of life is tenable: it correctly locates the ground of meaning in shared human practice rather than in private mind or abstract logic.

Body.

- *PI 19*. "To imagine a language means to imagine a form of life" - language and a mode of living are inseparable. - *Agreement in form of life, not opinion*. We agree "not in opinions but in form of life" - shared *doing*, which blocks both relativist and intellectualist misreadings. - *The lion remark*. "If a lion could talk, we could not understand him" - too different a form of life defeats understanding even where speech exists. - *Bedrock*. Justification ends in "This is simply what I do"; forms of life are "the given."

Tenability verdict. Defensible and explanatorily powerful - it explains why justification stops and why understanding needs a shared background; the fair limit is that "form of life" is under-defined, risking either triviality or a slide toward relativism if the largely *natural* basis is forgotten.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2023 Q4(c), 15 marks

Question: What were the main reasons that led Wittgenstein to shift from picture-theory of meaning to use-theory of meaning? Critically discuss.

Model solution

Directive: "Critically discuss" at 15 marks - give the *reasons* for the shift and one line of assessment. Answer in about 250 words.

Thesis. Wittgenstein abandoned the picture-theory for the use-theory because the picture-theory failed internally and mislocated the source of meaning; the later view trades systematic elegance for fidelity to actual practice.

Body - the ordered reasons.

- *The colour-exclusion problem (1929)*. The *Tractatus* held elementary propositions to be logically independent, yet "this spot is red (all over)" excludes "this spot is green." Wittgenstein could not repair this within the old system - the first structural crack he himself found. - *The Augustinian picture is too narrow*. "Every word names an object" works for "table" but collapses for "the", "if", "five", "pain", "meaning". If one model cannot cover these, meaning is not one thing. - *Meaning is use*. Positively, "the meaning of a word is its use in the language" - "for a large class of cases, though not for all" (PI 43). Words are tools; understanding is mastery of a technique. - *Ordinary language is in order*. Problems come from *misunderstanding* our language, not from a defective surface hiding an ideal logical

one - so the demand to build an ideal language is misdiagnosis. - *From theory to description*. Deepest of all: philosophy should **describe** ("Don't think, but look"), not construct a rival theory of meaning.

Critical assessment. The shift is well-motivated - the colour-exclusion crack is decisive against the old system and the Augustinian critique against referential semantics. Its cost is method: by renouncing a *theory* of meaning, the later view can look like it merely redescribes practice. The reply is that this is the point - its success-measure is dissolving confusion, not adding doctrine.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2024 Q1(d), 10 marks

Question: Why does later Wittgenstein think that there cannot be a language that only one person can speak — a language that is essentially private? Discuss.

Model solution

Directive: "Discuss" at 10 marks - give the core *reason* clearly. Answer in about 150 words.

Thesis. An essentially private language is impossible because meaning requires a public criterion of correct use, which a logically private sign cannot have.

Body.

- *Fix the target.* "Essentially private" = signs for sensations only the speaker could in principle know - not a code (translatable), not talking to oneself (public language spoken quietly). - *Correctness needs an independent standard* (PI 201, 258). To mean something by "S" I must be able to use it *rightly or wrongly*. Naming a private sensation "S", I have no check independent of my present impression that a later case is the *same*: "whatever is going to seem right to me is right. And that only means that here we can't talk about 'right'." - *The beetle* (PI 293). Whatever is in the private "box" "drops out as irrelevant"; the word's life is its public use.

Close. Since no independent criterion of correctness is available to the solitary sensation-namer, the sign fails to be a word at all - so a language "only one person can speak" in this strong sense is impossible. This denies not inner life but the private object's role as a foundation of meaning.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2025 Q3(a), 20 marks

Question: "We should look not to an ideal language which derives its meaning from facts and has a precise 'logical structure but empirically, to the ways in which languages are actually used.'" Explain the transition from early views of Wittgenstein to his later views on language and meaning with reference to this statement.

Printed-wording anomaly (preserved verbatim): Printed wording: the unmatched opening quotation before **logical structure** is visible in the official English line and is retained.

Model solution

Directive: "Explain the transition... with reference to this statement" at 20 marks - use the quotation as the hinge and expound the early-to-later movement in full. Answer in about 250-300 words.

Printed-wording anomaly (preserved verbatim): the quoted statement contains an **unmatched opening single-quote** before "logical structure" - it prints ...a precise 'logical structure but empirically...' with no closing quote where the sense expects one. Reproduce the statement as printed, flag the stray quotation mark, and do not silently "correct" it; UPSC provenance discipline rewards the candidate who notes the anomaly and proceeds.

Thesis. The statement encapsulates Wittgenstein's whole transition: away from an *ideal language whose meaning derives from picturing facts and possessing a precise logical structure*, toward an *empirical description of the ways language is actually used*.

Body - the transition.

- *The early view (the rejected pole of the quotation).* In the *Tractatus* (1921), a sentence is meaningful by **picturing** a possible fact; meaning derives from facts via a shared **logical structure/form**; analysis terminates in logically independent elementary propositions and simple names. The ideal is a logically perspicuous language.

- *The internal breakdown.* The **colour-exclusion problem (1929)** refuted the independence of elementary propositions; the **Augustinian** naming-picture proved too narrow ("the", "if", "five", "pain"). The defect was not a messy surface but the very model of meaning-as-picturing.
- *The later view (the endorsed pole).* "Look... empirically, to the ways in which languages are actually used": **meaning is use** (PI 43, "for a large class of cases, though not for all"); words are **tools**; there is no single essence but **family resemblance**; language is a plurality of **language-games** woven into **forms of life** (PI 19); understanding is **mastery of a technique**.
- *The methodological pay-off.* Philosophy becomes **description/therapy**, not theory: it assembles a perspicuous representation to dissolve confusions and "leaves everything as it is" (PI 124).

Verdict. The transition is from a top-down logical *theory* of an ideal language to a bottom-up *description* of ordinary use - more faithful to linguistic life, at the deliberate cost of a systematic theory of meaning.

ORIGINAL MCQ MASTERY SET - EXACTLY 40 QUESTIONS

Questions 1-32 are core coverage across all ten subtopics; Questions 33-40 are remedial items targeting the most common misreadings. Correct answers rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D 10 times.

MCQ 1

The central change from the Tractatus to the Philosophical Investigations is best described as a move from:

A. meaning as the picturing of facts to meaning as use in a language B. meaning as use to meaning as private mental imagery C. ordinary language to an ideal logical language D. ethics to philosophy of mathematics

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The later philosophy replaces the picture-theory (a sentence pictures a possible fact) with meaning as use in a form of life. The other options invert or misstate the direction of the shift.

MCQ 2

Which internal problem, noticed by Wittgenstein around 1929, exposed a structural crack in the Tractatus?

A. the paradox of the liar B. the colour-exclusion problem - that 'a is red all over' excludes 'a is green all over', contradicting the independence of elementary propositions C. Russell's theory of descriptions D. the private-language argument

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The Tractatus required elementary propositions to be logically independent, but colour incompatibility shows two such propositions can exclude each other. The private-language argument is a later, separate result.

MCQ 3

The 'Augustinian picture of language' that Wittgenstein criticises is the idea that:

A. language is a calculus of truth-functions B. philosophy should describe rather than explain C. every word functions by naming an object, and sentences are combinations of such names D. meaning is determined by community consensus

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Wittgenstein opens the Investigations with Augustine to typify the naming-picture: words are names of objects. It works for 'table' but collapses for 'the', 'if', 'five', 'pain'.

MCQ 4

Which formulation states Wittgenstein's use-thesis with the qualification he actually gives in PI 43?

A. the meaning of a word is always identical with its use B. every word is a name whose meaning is its bearer C. meaning is a private mental act of interpretation D. 'for a large class of cases - though not for all - ... the meaning of a word is its use in the language'

Correct answer: D

Explanation: PI 43 is explicitly hedged: 'for a large class of cases - though not for all'. Flattening it into 'meaning is always use' misreports the text; the naming/interpretation options are the views he rejects.

MCQ 5

For the later Wittgenstein, to understand a word is primarily to:

A. have mastered the technique of using it - to be able to 'go on' correctly B. possess a private mental image that accompanies it C. know the object it names D. be able to give a real definition in necessary and sufficient conditions

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Understanding is a public, demonstrable ability (mastery of a technique), not a private inner episode, a naming relation, or the possession of an essence-definition.

MCQ 6

The 'toolbox' analogy is meant to show that:

A. all words ultimately perform the single function of naming B. words have diverse functions, as tools do, so we should ask a word's job rather than its object C. language is a precise calculus like a set of measuring instruments D. only nouns are genuinely meaningful

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Just as a hammer, glue and ruler do different jobs, words perform diverse functions; asking 'what object does it name?' misfits most of them.

MCQ 7

According to the family-resemblance idea, the various activities we call 'games' are united by:

A. a single defining property present in every game B. an agreed stipulative definition C. a network of overlapping and criss-crossing similarities, with no one feature common to all D. their shared aim of amusement

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Wittgenstein finds 'a complicated network of similarities overlapping and criss-crossing', not a common essence; some games lack winners, some skill, some amusement.

MCQ 8

The injunction 'Don't think, but look!' expresses Wittgenstein's demand that we:

A. deduce the hidden essence behind a concept B. trust introspection over observation C. replace ordinary language with a logical notation D. describe the actual variety of uses instead of positing a common essence

Correct answer: D

Explanation: It is a methodological slogan for description over theory: inspect how the word is actually used rather than assume a concealed defining feature.

MCQ 9

On Wittgenstein's view, a concept with blurred or fuzzy boundaries is:

- A. still perfectly usable - sharp boundaries are not required for a concept to function
- B. meaningless until sharpened by analysis
- C. a sign of a defective natural language
- D. acceptable only in poetry, not in philosophy

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Blurred edges are a feature, not a defect: 'is a photograph a picture?' need not have a forced answer for 'picture' to work. Demanding sharpness everywhere is the error.

MCQ 10

A 'language-game' (Sprachspiel) in Wittgenstein's technical sense is:

- A. a competitive contest played with words
- B. language together with the activities into which it is woven
- C. a purely formal calculus of signs
- D. a children's game that teaches grammar

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The term denotes 'the whole, consisting of language and the actions into which it is woven'. It is not a contest, a formalism, or a pedagogic device.

MCQ 11

The builders' example ('Slab!', 'Block!') is meant to illustrate that:

- A. all languages must share one logical form
- B. primitive words are meaningless without full grammar
- C. a small set of words used in a shared practice can be a complete language, not a defective fragment of ours
- D. ostensive definition alone fixes meaning

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The 'Slab!' language is complete for its purpose, showing meaning needs a role in a practice, not a universal logical form or a full natural grammar.

MCQ 12

For Wittgenstein, we come to follow the rules of a language-game chiefly through:

- A. intuiting a Platonic form
- B. an explicit contract among speakers
- C. grasping a hidden calculus by introspection
- D. training - drill, examples and correction within a practice

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Rules are learned by being trained into a practice, not by grasping an essence, signing a convention, or introspecting a calculus.

MCQ 13

PI 19's remark 'to imagine a language means to imagine a form of life' asserts that:

- A. a language is inseparable from a mode of living and acting
- B. languages can be designed independently of any human practice
- C. imagination is the source of linguistic meaning
- D. forms of life are private mental states

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Language and a form of life are inseparable; the remark is the textual basis of the 2022 question. The other options detach language from practice or privatise it.

MCQ 14

When Wittgenstein says humans 'agree in the language they use', he means agreement:

- A. in explicitly stated opinions and theories
- B. in form of life - shared ways of acting - not in opinions
- C. reached by majority vote
- D. guaranteed by a shared logical structure

Correct answer: B

Explanation: 'Not agreement in opinions but in form of life.' It is shared doing, which blocks both the intellectualist (shared beliefs) and the merely conventional (vote) readings.

MCQ 15

'If a lion could talk, we could not understand him' is used to make the point that:

- A. animals lack vocal cords for speech
- B. translation between human languages is impossible
- C. understanding presupposes a shared form of life, not merely shared vocabulary
- D. solitary rule-following is possible

Correct answer: C

Explanation: A form of life too unlike ours would leave the words without shared purchase; understanding needs a shared background of activity and reaction, not just words.

MCQ 16

The rule-following 'paradox' of PI 201 is that:

- A. rules are always vague
- B. no one ever really follows a rule
- C. rules must be written to be valid
- D. 'no course of action could be determined by a rule, because every course of action can be made out to accord with the rule'

Correct answer: D

Explanation: PI 201 states the paradox verbatim: any continuation can be squared with the rule under some interpretation, so interpretation alone determines nothing.

MCQ 17

Wittgenstein's resolution of the paradox is that grasping a rule is:

- A. a practice or custom, exhibited in obeying the rule and going against it in actual cases
- B. a private act of interpretation
- C. a matter of consulting a further rule
- D. an infallible intuition of meaning

Correct answer: A

Explanation: 'There is a way of grasping a rule which is not an interpretation, but which is exhibited in what we call obeying the rule.' Rule-following is a trained practice.

MCQ 18

Why does adding another rule to 'interpret' the first fail to solve the paradox?

- A. because rules cannot be written down
- B. because it launches an infinite regress - the new rule itself needs interpreting
- C. because interpretations are always correct
- D. because only experts may interpret rules

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Each interpreting rule needs its own interpretation, and so on without end; the regress is why Wittgenstein locates correctness in practice, not interpretation.

MCQ 19

On the rule-following considerations, a rule that only one person could in principle check would:

- A. be the clearest kind of rule
- B. be validated by private conviction
- C. lack any genuine distinction between following it and merely seeming to - so it is no rule
- D. be correct whenever it feels correct

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Without a criterion independent of one's impression, 'right' collapses into 'seems right'. This is the bridge from rule-following to the private-language argument.

MCQ 20

In Wittgenstein's argument, an 'essentially private language' means a language whose words:

- A. are a secret code known only to a spy
- B. are spoken quietly to oneself in soliloquy
- C. belong to a rare, endangered natural tongue
- D. refer to sensations only the speaker could in principle know, so no one else could understand it

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The target is *logical* privacy, not secrecy or soliloquy (both of which use ordinary, public language). Getting this target right is the commonest exam make-or-break.

MCQ 21

In the private diarist example (PI 258), the attempt to name a recurring private sensation 'S' fails because:

- A. there is no criterion independent of the diarist's impression to fix whether a later 'S' is the same, so 'correct' loses its grip
- B. the diarist forgets the definition overnight
- C. sensations are too fleeting to be written down
- D. the word 'S' is too short to carry meaning

Correct answer: A

Explanation: With nothing beyond present seeming to check sameness, 'whatever seems right is right' - which means we cannot speak of right at all. The failure is logical, not psychological.

MCQ 22

The 'beetle in a box' (PI 293) is designed to show that:

- A. everyone's inner sensations are qualitatively identical
- B. if a sensation-word's use is public, the private object it supposedly names 'drops out as irrelevant' - the box might even be empty
- C. we can never know that other people have minds
- D. sensations do not exist

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The point is semantic, not sceptical or eliminativist: meaning is carried by public use, so the private 'object' does no work - not that other minds are unknowable or that sensations are unreal.

MCQ 23

Which sentence from PI 258 most directly states the collapse of correctness in a private language?

- A. 'The limits of my language are the limits of my world.'
- B. 'What we cannot speak about we must pass over in silence.'
- C. 'Whatever is going to seem right to me is right. And that only means that here we can't talk about "right".'
- D. 'A picture held us captive.'

Correct answer: C

Explanation: This is the PI 258 line. The first two are Tractatus remarks; 'a picture held us captive' is PI 115 - none of those three states the private-correctness collapse.

MCQ 24

The distinction between a 'criterion' and a 'symptom' allows Wittgenstein to:

- A. reduce mental states to behaviour B. deny that anyone is ever in pain C. treat sensation-talk as pure induction D. anchor sensation-words to public circumstances without reducing sensations to behaviour

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Criteria are meaning-constituting and defeasible, so pain is publicly criterion-governed yet not identical with behaviour - a third way between inner-object semantics and behaviourism.

MCQ 25

A criterion differs from a symptom in that a criterion is:

- A. grammatical - part of what fixes the meaning of the term - whereas a symptom is an empirically correlated accompaniment B. always more reliable than any symptom C. discovered by experiment, unlike a symptom D. private, unlike a public symptom

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The difference is in kind: criteria belong to grammar (meaning), symptoms to inductive correlation. Calling criteria merely 'more reliable symptoms' collapses the distinction.

MCQ 26

PI 580, 'An "inner process" stands in need of outward criteria', is best read as:

- A. a denial that inner processes exist B. a claim about the grammar of inner talk - such talk is anchored to public criteria, not that the inner is unreal C. a behaviourist reduction of mind to motion D. a statement that only behaviour is real

Correct answer: B

Explanation: It states the grammar of psychological concepts, not an ontological denial. The inner is not eliminated; it is shown to require outward criteria to be meaningfully spoken of.

MCQ 27

Wittgenstein's remarks at PI 304 ('not a something, but not a nothing either') and 307-308 show that he:

- A. is a classical behaviourist B. believes sensations are physical objects C. rejects the picture of the inner as a private object grounding meaning (a 'grammatical fiction'), without denying the inner life D. thinks all talk of sensations is nonsense

Correct answer: C

Explanation: He rejects the *object*-model of the inner as a semantic foundation, not the reality of sensation - hence 'not a something, but not a nothing either'. This is the reply to the behaviourism charge.

MCQ 28

Wittgenstein's answer to 'What is your aim in philosophy?' is:

- A. to construct a complete theory of meaning B. to deduce the a priori structure of the world C. to establish the foundations of mathematics D. 'To show the fly the way out of the fly-bottle' (PI 309)

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Philosophy dissolves rather than solves: it releases us from a confusion we are trapped in, as one lets a fly out of a bottle - it does not build a rival theory.

MCQ 29

'Philosophy may in no way interfere with the actual use of language... it leaves everything as it is' (PI 124) expresses Wittgenstein's:

A. quietism - philosophy describes and advances no theses, changing nothing in ordinary practice B. revisionism about ordinary language C. programme to build an ideal language D. scepticism about the external world

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The later method is descriptive and non-interfering; 'if one tried to advance theses in philosophy... everyone would agree to them' (PI 128). It is neither revisionist nor sceptical.

MCQ 30

The positive tool Wittgenstein calls a 'perspicuous (surveyable) representation' (übersichtliche Darstellung, PI 122) is:

A. a formal proof of a philosophical thesis B. an arrangement of the grammar we already know so that we 'command a clear view' and 'see connexions' C. an ideal logical language D. an empirical psychological theory of understanding

Correct answer: B

Explanation: It re-orders familiar grammatical facts to make confusions dissolve; it produces understanding that consists in 'seeing connexions', not new empirical or logical doctrine.

MCQ 31

The duck-rabbit figure illustrates 'seeing an aspect' because:

A. the drawing physically changes between duck and rabbit B. it proves that perception is purely passive reception of data C. the same unchanged marks can be seen now as a duck, now as a rabbit - the 'dawning of an aspect', which is 'half visual experience, half thought' D. only trained artists can perceive it

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Nothing on the page alters; what changes is the aspect under which it is seen. Wittgenstein places seeing-as between bare perception and interpretation.

MCQ 32

The notion of 'aspect-blindness' is introduced to show that:

A. some people have defective retinas B. aspect-perception is identical with logical inference C. seeing-as can be reduced to naming D. aspect-perception presupposes the mastery of a technique or concept, so perception itself is shot through with our trained capacities

Correct answer: D

Explanation: By imagining someone who cannot experience an aspect-switch, Wittgenstein isolates what such perception adds - it depends on conceptual mastery, linking perception to meaning-as-use.

Remedial MCQ 33

REMEDIAL. A student says 'a private language is just a personal code no one else has learned yet.' The correct clarification is:

A. a code is translatable and shareable, hence public; the argument targets a *logically* private language whose sensations are in principle unknowable to others B. there is no difference between a code and a private language C. a private language is simply talking to oneself D. private languages are common among twins

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Codes and soliloquy use ordinary public language. The argument concerns logical privacy - the very possibility of meaning under such privacy - not contingent secrecy.

Remedial MCQ 34

REMEDIAL. Which provenance statement about the Philosophical Investigations is accurate?

- A. Wittgenstein published it himself in 1921
- B. it was published posthumously in 1953, edited by G. E. M. Anscombe and Rush Rhees, Anscombe translating, Wittgenstein having died in 1951
- C. it was co-authored with Bertrand Russell
- D. it first appeared in German in 1922 as the Tractatus

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The Investigations is posthumous (1953); never write 'Wittgenstein published' it. 1921/1922 and Russell belong to the Tractatus period, not the Investigations.

Remedial MCQ 35

REMEDIAL. The most common misreading of 'family resemblance' is to think it claims:

- A. that concepts can lack sharp boundaries
- B. that we should look at actual uses
- C. that all instances share one hidden common property called 'family resemblance'
- D. that games form an overlapping network of similarities

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The whole point is that there is *no* single common feature - only overlapping similarities. Treating 'family resemblance' as itself the shared essence inverts the doctrine.

Remedial MCQ 36

REMEDIAL. The strongest reason Wittgenstein is *not* a behaviourist is that:

- A. he denies that pain-behaviour exists
- B. he says sensations are physical objects
- C. he reduces every mental term to a disposition
- D. criteria are grammatical and *defeasible*, so pain and pain-behaviour can come apart (e.g. pretence), and he affirms the inner life while denying only the inner *object* as meaning's foundation

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Defeasibility is the hinge: a behaviourist identity of pain with behaviour cannot allow pretence, but Wittgenstein's criterial account requires that they can diverge.

Remedial MCQ 37

REMEDIAL. The rule-following paradox (PI 201) is ultimately resolved by:

- A. appeal to a shared practice - a trained, customary way of 'going on' - rather than by supplying a further interpreting rule
- B. a private act of intuition
- C. adding a second, clearer rule
- D. abandoning the notion of correctness altogether

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Grasping a rule is 'exhibited in obeying', a practice; a further rule only regresses, and correctness is retained (not abandoned) via public practice.

Remedial MCQ 38

REMEDIAL. 'Wittgenstein's critique of solipsism culminates in the critique of private language' because:

- A. solipsism is refuted by proving the external world exists
- B. the solipsist's privileged private inner world could not be expressed in any language, so his position cannot even be stated - the private-language argument does the work
- C. solipsism and private language are unrelated topics
- D. the solipsist simply changes his mind

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The route (2019 PYQ) is dissolution, not empirical refutation: if a purely private naming cannot fix even one rule, the solipsist's inner world cannot be spoken, so solipsism self-undermines.

Remedial MCQ 39

REMEDIAL. 'Forms of life' function in Wittgenstein's philosophy as:

A. a proof of cultural relativism B. a synonym for biological species only C. the bedrock where justification ends - 'This is simply what I do' - the given background of shared human practice D. a private mental foundation for meaning

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Forms of life are 'the given' at which reasons run out; the basis is largely natural shared practice, which is why it does not amount to 'anything goes' relativism.

Remedial MCQ 40

REMEDIAL. Seeing the duck-rabbit now as a duck, now as a rabbit, is best classified as:

A. a straightforward inductive inference from lines to animal B. a hypothesis we test against evidence C. a change in the physical stimulus D. an experienced 'dawning of an aspect' that is not merely an interpretation or inference

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Wittgenstein insists seeing-as is lived, not concluded: 'it is like seeing, and again not like seeing'. Reducing it to inference is precisely the intellectualist error he blocks.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Three original questions authored for this package (not PYQs), one each at 10, 15 and 20 marks, with full model solutions.

Original Mains 1

Original practice - GS/Optional style - 10 marks - answer in about 150 words

Question: State the rule-following paradox of Philosophical Investigations 201 and explain how Wittgenstein resolves it.

Model solution

Thesis. PI 201 shows that meaning cannot be fixed by interpretation alone; rule-following is a shared practice.

The paradox. "No course of action could be determined by a rule, because every course of action can be made out to accord with the rule." Any finite series (2, 4, 6...) fits indefinitely many rules, so a pupil who writes 1004 after 1000 can claim to be obeying 'add 2'. If accord is a matter of interpretation, interpretation determines nothing.

Why more rules fail. Supplying a rule to interpret the rule needs its own interpretation - an infinite regress.

Resolution. "There is a way of grasping a rule which is not an interpretation, but which is exhibited in what we call 'obeying the rule'." Rule-following is a **custom/practice**, learned by training and grounded in a form of life. Normativity survives: right and wrong are fixed by shared practice, not private seeming.

Close. The result feeds directly into the private-language argument: no public practice, no genuine rule.

Original Mains 2

Original practice - GS/Optional style - 15 marks - answer in about 250 words

Question: 'Wittgenstein's account of sensation-language reduces the mind to behaviour.' Do you agree? Discuss using the distinction between criteria and symptoms.

Model solution

Thesis. The charge is mistaken. Wittgenstein anchors sensation-words to public *criteria* without identifying sensations with behaviour; his criterial account is a third position between Cartesian inner-object semantics and behaviourism.

Setting up the charge. Having rejected the private object (diary 258; beetle 293), Wittgenstein says sensation-words connect to the world through publicly available circumstances. A behaviourist concludes: then pain just *is*

pain-behaviour.

The criterion/symptom distinction. A **criterion** is a *grammatical* connection - part of what fixes the meaning of the term; a **symptom** is an *inductive* correlate learned by experience. Wincing, guarding and crying are criteria for 'pain'; a pallor we have found to accompany pain is a symptom. What is criterion and what is symptom can even shift with knowledge (the angina analogy).

Why this defeats the charge.

- *Defeasibility.* Criteria can be overridden (pretence, suppression) without ceasing to be criteria. So pain and pain-behaviour can come apart - impossible on a behaviourist identity. - *PI 580.* "An 'inner process' stands in need of outward criteria" states the *grammar* of inner talk; it does not deny the inner. - *PI 304, 307-308.* He rejects the inner *object* as a semantic foundation (a "grammatical fiction"), not the inner life: "not a something, but not a nothing either." - *First-person avowal.* "It hurts" is an expression, not a criterion-based report; criteria govern the third-person case (asymmetry).

Verdict. Disagree with the charge: the account preserves the inner life while denying it the role of a private meaning-foundation. Its fair vulnerability is the under-specification of "criterion", not a covert behaviourism.

Original Mains 3

Original practice - GS/Optional style - 20 marks - answer in about 300 words

Question: 'Philosophy leaves everything as it is.' Critically examine the later Wittgenstein's conception of philosophy as description and therapy.

Model solution

Thesis. For the later Wittgenstein, philosophical problems are conceptual confusions bred when "language goes on holiday"; philosophy's task is not to build theories but to dissolve these confusions by description - and this therapeutic, quietist conception is powerful, though it faces a genuine self-reference objection.

The conception.

- *Diagnosis.* "Philosophy is a battle against the bewitchment of our intelligence by means of language" (PI 109). A word torn from its home language-game ("What is time? meaning? the self?") generates pseudo-problems. - *Method.* Not explanation but **description**: "Don't think, but look." The positive tool is a **perspicuous (surveyable) representation** (PI 122) - arranging the grammar we already command so we "command a clear view" and "see connexions".
- *Result.* Problems are **dissolved**, not solved: "to show the fly the way out of the fly-bottle" (PI 309).
- *Self-limit (quietism).* "Philosophy may in no way interfere with the actual use of language... it leaves everything as it is" (PI 124); it advances no theses (PI 128); "there is not a philosophical method, though there are... different therapies" (PI 133).

Critical examination.

- *Strengths.* It explains why philosophical problems are peculiarly stubborn (they are not empirical), and it dissolves entire pseudo-debates (private objects, the demand for essences). It is continuous with meaning-as-use: if meaning is use, confusions are misuses. - *Objections.* (i) *Self-reference*: "there are no philosophical theses" looks like a thesis; a purely neutral description may be impossible (description is theory-laden). (ii) *Conservatism*: "leaves everything as it is" seems to forbid legitimate conceptual revision (in science, ethics, politics). - *Replies.* Wittgenstein offers **reminders**, not a metaphysics, and measures success by intellectual **peace** ("the real discovery is the one that... gives philosophy peace", PI 133); "leaves everything as it is" concerns *ordinary use*, not first-order inquiry.

Verdict. A profound reorientation of philosophy from doctrine to clarification; its deflationary self-image is hard to state without strain, but its diagnostic power over conceptual confusion is its enduring contribution.